

Lettuce Seedling Grow Guide

For Alderan / Alderaan lettuce and general lettuce seedlings

Transplanting - Spacing - Watering - Feeding - Pest Control - Harvesting

Best for	Home gardens, kitchen gardens, raised beds, containers, and small farm production
Main customer use	Seedlings transplanted from trays into beds, bags, pots, or field rows
Support	Send plant photos by WhatsApp if you see pests, wilting, yellowing, holes, or rot

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Quick Rescue: If You See This, Do This

Use this page first. It helps customers act quickly before reading the full guide.

What you see	Most likely cause	What to do first
Seedling wilts after planting	Transplant shock, sun stress, dry roots	Shade for 2-3 days, water gently, transplant evening or early morning
Leaves have holes	Caterpillars, slugs, snails, grasshoppers	Check early morning/evening, remove pests, use barriers or safe bait
Leaves look sticky or curled	Aphids or whiteflies	Check underside of leaves, spray mild soap solution, repeat every 3-5 days
Leaf edges turn brown	Heat stress, dry soil, fertilizer burn	Give afternoon shade, water evenly, avoid strong fertilizer
Plant stretches tall and weak	Too little light or overcrowding	Give brighter morning light and space plants properly
Leaves turn yellow	Overwatering, low nitrogen, poor roots	Check drainage, feed lightly, avoid soggy soil
Leaves rot near soil line	Soil too wet, poor airflow, disease	Remove bad leaves, improve spacing, water at soil level
Plant tastes bitter	Heat stress, old plant, bolting	Harvest younger, give shade, keep soil moist
Tall center stalk appears	Bolting from heat, age, or stress	Harvest immediately and plant fresh seedlings

Quick Numbers for Lettuce Seedlings

Item	Target or range
Crop type	Cool-season leafy vegetable
Best growing temperature	15-21 C / 59-70 F
Heat stress risk	Above 24-27 C / 75-80 F
Seed germination	2-10 days
Transplant age	3-5 weeks after sowing
Hardening-off period	5-7 days
Ready to harvest after transplant	25-45 days for leaf lettuce, depending on size
Leaf lettuce harvest from seed	40-60 days
Head lettuce harvest from seed	70-80 days
Sunlight in hot areas	4-6 hours, with afternoon shade
Sunlight in cooler/milder areas	6+ hours
Soil pH target	6.0-7.0
Water target	About 1 inch / 25 mm per week, more often in containers
Container depth	6-8 inches minimum
Container spacing	6-10 inches, depending on harvest size

Important: In hot Jamaican conditions, lettuce often performs better with morning sun and light afternoon shade than with harsh full-day sun.

Hardening Off Before Transplanting

Hardening off means slowly preparing tray seedlings for direct sun, wind, and outdoor conditions before planting.

Day	Exposure
Day 1-2	Bright shade for 2-3 hours
Day 3-4	Morning sun for 2-4 hours
Day 5-6	Morning sun plus bright afternoon shade
Day 7	Ready to transplant, preferably late evening

Do not move tray seedlings straight from shade into full hot sun. Keep tray cells moist while hardening off. If seedlings wilt badly, move them back to shade and water gently.

Best Time to Transplant

Best option	Time
Early morning	Before 8:30 a.m.
Late evening	After 4:30 p.m.
Hot weather choice	Late evening is safest

Before planting, water seedlings 1-2 hours ahead and prepare the bed or container before removing seedlings from the tray.

Transplanting From Seedling Trays

- Water seedling tray 1-2 hours before planting.
- Prepare holes before removing seedlings from the tray.
- Gently push each seedling out from the bottom of the tray cell.
- Keep as much of the root ball together as possible.
- Plant at the same depth as the tray soil level.
- Do not bury the center growing point or crown.
- Press soil gently around the roots without crushing the stem.
- Water immediately after planting.
- Give light shade for 2-3 days if the sun is hot.
- Check morning and evening for the first 3-5 days.

Lettuce Warning

Do not cover the middle crown of the lettuce plant with soil. If soil gets packed into the center, the plant can rot or grow poorly.

Small-farmer note: Plant the whole tray as soon as possible after pickup. If planting is delayed, keep seedlings in bright shade, water lightly, and avoid stacking trays in heat.

Spacing Guide

Spacing depends on whether the customer wants baby leaves, loose leaves, romaine/cos type, or full heads. For most home customers, 8-10 inches apart is a simple safe instruction.

Lettuce use	Plant spacing	Row spacing
Baby leaf harvest	4-6 inches	8-12 inches
Loose leaf lettuce	6-10 inches	12-18 inches
Romaine/cos type	8-12 inches	12-24 inches
Butterhead type	8-12 inches	12-18 inches
Crisphead/head lettuce	12-15 inches	18-30 inches
Container growing	6-10 inches	Depends on container

Simple customer instruction: for 2-6 plants, plant lettuce 8-10 inches apart in a container at least 6-8 inches deep, with drainage holes.

Sunlight, Heat, Shade, and Water

Condition	Recommendation
Cool or mild weather	6 hours of sun is good
Hot Jamaican conditions	4-6 hours sun plus afternoon shade
Best sun	Morning sun
Best shade period	12 p.m.-3 p.m. if heat is strong
Shade cloth	30-50% shade in hot conditions
Heat stress risk	Above 24-27 C / 75-80 F
Bolting risk	Increases with heat, age, dry soil, and stress

Watering Guide

Stage	Watering direction
First 3 days after transplant	Check morning and evening
First 7 days	Keep soil evenly moist
Established plants	Water when top 1 inch of soil begins to dry
Containers	May need water daily in hot weather
Rainy periods	Reduce watering to avoid rot

Water at soil level where possible. Avoid splashing soil onto leaves and avoid soaking leaves late in the evening.

Soil and Feeding Guide

Soil need	Target
Texture	Loose, rich, well-draining
Organic matter	Compost or well-rotted manure
pH	6.0-7.0
Bed type	Raised bed or mound where soil stays wet
Drainage	Water should not sit around roots

Simple Container Mix

Material	Share
Good topsoil or potting mix	50%
Compost	30%
Coco coir, dry organic matter, or drainage-supporting material	20%

Feeding Schedule

Stage	Timing	Feeding
At transplant	Day 0	Compost in soil
After settling	7-10 days after transplant	Light liquid feed or mild nitrogen feed
Active leaf growth	Every 10-14 days	Light feeding
Final week before harvest	Last 7 days	Avoid heavy feeding; focus on water and clean leaves

Avoid overfeeding. Too much fertilizer can cause soft weak leaves, leaf burn, bitter taste, pest problems, and rot in wet weather.

Common Lettuce Pests

Pest	Signs	Action
Aphids	Small soft insects, curled leaves, sticky leaves, ants	Spray off with water, use mild soap, repeat every 3-5 days
Whiteflies	Tiny white insects fly up when touched, yellowing, sticky leaves	Spray under leaves, use yellow sticky traps, keep weeds down
Caterpillars	Holes in leaves, black droppings, chewed edges	Check early morning/evening, handpick, use netting if needed
Slugs and snails	Ragged holes, slime trails, worse after rain	Remove hiding spots, use barriers, check at night/early morning
Leafminers	White or winding tunnels inside leaves	Remove affected leaves, keep weeds down, use insect netting if pressure is high
Thrips	Silvery marks, distorted young leaves	Remove damaged leaves, reduce weeds, use sticky traps

Spray Safety

- Spray early morning or late evening, not in harsh sun.
- Always test homemade spray on a few leaves first.
- Focus on the underside of leaves where pests hide.
- Repeat treatment every 3-5 days until pests are controlled.

Common Lettuce Diseases

Disease	Signs	Action
Damping off	Young seedling collapses near soil line; stem looks pinched or rotten	Avoid overwatering, improve airflow, use clean mix, do not overcrowd trays
Lettuce drop / Sclerotinia	Lower leaves rot near soil, plant collapses, white mold may appear near base	Improve spacing, remove infected plants, avoid wet leaves sitting on soil
Downy mildew	Yellow patches on upper leaf, gray/purple growth under leaves	Improve airflow, water early, avoid overhead watering, remove affected leaves
Bacterial soft rot	Wet slimy rot, bad smell, leaves collapse	Remove affected leaves/plants, reduce moisture, avoid damaging leaves
Viral disease	Mosaic patterns, stunted plants, distorted leaves, uneven yellowing	Control aphids/whiteflies, remove badly affected plants, keep weeds down

Disease prevention starts with clean hands, clean tools, good spacing, morning watering, and removing diseased leaves early.

Clean-Hands and Tobacco Warning

Important plant health warning: Do not smoke, handle cigarettes, or handle tobacco products and then touch seedlings without washing your hands first.

For tomato and pepper crops, tobacco mosaic virus is a major concern. For lettuce, the same clean-hand rule is still important because dirty hands, tools, trays, and diseased plant material can spread problems from plant to plant.

Before Touching Seedlings

- Wash hands with soap and water.
- Do not rest cigarettes on seedling trays.
- Do not blow smoke directly onto plants.
- Do not handle diseased plants and then touch healthy seedlings.
- Clean scissors, knives, and tools before harvest.
- Remove diseased leaves from the growing area.

Customer note: This rule is especially important for small farmers handling many seedlings from trays, because one contaminated hand or tool can touch many plants quickly.

Leaf Color, Bolting, and Bitter Lettuce

Leaf look	Possible cause	What to do
Bright green, firm leaves	Healthy	Continue steady watering
Pale green leaves	Low nitrogen or poor light	Feed lightly, improve sunlight
Yellow lower leaves	Overwatering, age, low nitrogen	Check drainage and feed lightly
Brown edges	Heat, dry soil, fertilizer burn	Shade, water evenly, reduce fertilizer
Limp leaves at midday only	Heat stress	Shade during hottest hours
Limp leaves morning and evening	Root or water problem	Check soil moisture and roots
Slimy leaves	Rot or disease	Remove bad leaves, reduce wetness
Tall center stalk	Bolting	Harvest immediately

Bolting means lettuce is switching from leaf production to flowering/seed production. Main causes are heat above 24-27 C / 75-80 F, plant age, dry soil, and stress.

If lettuce starts bolting, harvest immediately. For future crops, use afternoon shade, keep soil moist, and harvest outer leaves earlier.

Harvesting Guide

Harvest method	Timing
Baby leaves	About 20-30 days after transplant, depending on size
Outer-leaf harvest	Start when plant has 6-8 strong leaves
Full loose-leaf harvest	About 30-45 days after transplant
Head lettuce harvest	About 60-70 days after transplant
Harvest frequency	Every 3-7 days for outer leaves

Best Harvest Time

- Harvest early morning before heat builds up.
- Use clean scissors or a clean knife.
- Harvest outer leaves first for continued production.
- Leave the center growing point if you want more leaves.
- Do not remove more than 1/3 of the plant at one time.
- Keep harvested lettuce out of direct sun.

Small Farmer and Home Garden Notes

For Small Farmers Planting Many Seedlings

- Use raised beds if soil holds water.
- Keep rows straight for easier weeding and harvesting.
- Use 8-12 inch plant spacing for most leaf lettuce production.
- Keep 12-18 inches between rows for hand weeding.
- Use mulch, weed mat, or clean bed edges where possible.
- Use 30-50% shade cloth in hot conditions.
- Plant in batches every 7-14 days for continuous harvest.
- Harvest early morning and keep leaves shaded after harvest.

For Home Garden Customers Buying 2-6 Seedlings

- Use a container at least 6-8 inches deep with drainage holes.
- Space plants 8-10 inches apart.
- Place container where it gets morning sun and afternoon shade.
- Water before leaves wilt.
- Harvest outer leaves every 3-7 days once plants are large enough.
- Replant fresh seedlings every 3-4 weeks for steady lettuce supply.

Weekly Care Checklist and Support

Frequency	What to check
Every day	Soil moisture, wilting, harsh afternoon sun, fresh pest damage
Every 3-5 days	Underside of leaves, aphids, whiteflies, caterpillars, leafminers, damaged leaves
Every 7-10 days	Light feeding if pale, weeds, spacing, airflow, mulch

Need help with your lettuce seedlings?

Send clear photos by WhatsApp: full plant, damaged leaves, underside of leaves, soil or container, and any insects you see.

WhatsApp: (876) 372-7415

References used for general lettuce guidance: university and agriculture extension resources on lettuce maturity, spacing, watering, heat management, common pests, and diseases. Local conditions may vary by shade, rainfall, soil, and season.

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